satisfied yourself about her credentials? If not, you have failed in your duty as secretary.'

Naturally, Verma was shocked to hear what I had to say, but kept quiet. It appeared he had realized the merit of my questioning him on a fundamental issue. My sincerest apologies to Sonia Gandhi, who was obviously the subject of the above conversation. However, at the time I could think of citing no better example to defend my honour as my loyalty to the country had come into focus as a result of a decision that had obviously been taken at her husband's behest.

I finally agreed to go to Tokyo as one of the ministers in the embassy of India in November 1990. There were a number of reasons for my accepting that offer. Both my son and daughter had joined undergraduate courses, and the family was facing a sort of a financial crunch because of that. I could see that, like some of their friends, they too wanted to see more of the world, and possibly study abroad, though they never mentioned it. Also, the post was specially upgraded to the rank of minister for me.

Despite my outwardly silent satyagraha, I continued to get 'outstanding' appraisals in my annual service records. That was evident from the proceedings of the departmental promotion committee (DPC) held in December 1987, which had considered the cases of officers of four batches (1962 to1965) together for promotion from director to joint secretary rank, wherein I had superseded officers two years senior to me. As a result, I was at the top of the panel approved for appointment as joint secretary. Though all the approved officers were simultaneously promoted as joint secretaries to avoid embarrassment to the superseded officers, I was in line to head the Department, when the time came for it.